

Draft — new to the process. Hackney is the newest borough working through this — this page holds what a recent session surfaced, checked against what Lambeth, Newham, Tower Hamlets and Camden + Islington already learned.

DRAFT · WORKING NOTE · SEPT 2026

DRAFT — WORKING GROUP NOTE — HACKNEY, 2026

Hackney doesn't have to *start from zero*.

Four other boroughs have already built, or are building, a version of what Hackney is now working out from scratch. This page holds the honest state of Hackney's own effort, checked directly against what the rest of this working group already learned the hard way — and sets out the concrete next steps, not another open-ended conversation.

[SEE WHAT'S NEXT ↓](#)[READ THE SHAREABLE OVERVIEW ↗](#)[OPEN THE FULL WORKING GROUP ↗](#)

4

HUBS ALREADY LIVE OR FORMING, TO LEARN FROM

~9 pallets

WAREHOUSE SPACE NOW INDICATED, STAMFORD HILL

12 Oct

PROVISIONAL DATE FOR THE GROUP'S NEXT MONTHLY SESSION

0

CONFIRMED LEAD ORGANISATION, STILL THE OPEN QUESTION

— STATED PLAINLY, NOT SMOOTHED OVER

Where Hackney is right now

The group's structuring session was candid about this: rather than wait for a lead to be appointed, it agreed one concrete first move everyone could act on immediately. That's a clearer starting point than pretending there's already a plan.

Hackney's own ambition is a collective food co-op: a way for the borough's community food groups to buy, store and share food together, backed by a dedicated hub and space. It grew out of the same question the rest of this group is asking — how does a borough support many small, independent community food efforts as one collective, rather than each fending for itself.

What's missing isn't ambition or goodwill. It's a lead. No single organisation has been asked, or has stepped up, to actually drive it — said openly in the room, not glossed over. Rather than let that stall things, the group agreed a first move everyone can act on now: calling round every Hackney community food organisation directly to find out what they actually spend on food each month. A written survey tried this earlier and got almost no responses; picking up the phone, building the relationship at the same time as collecting the number, is the agreed replacement. Dark Matter Labs has offered to help convene and structure the process; the decision about who actually leads, and who does the buying, stays with the organisations doing the work.

One concrete option already exists: an independent grocer in Stamford Hill, already trusted by community organisations in both Hackney and neighbouring Haringey, has ambient warehouse space available — now indicated at up to around nine pallets — and is open to hosting a small collective-buying pilot. The real gap isn't the space; it's the practical labour of sorting and delivery, which needs dedicated support to set up properly. Two smaller options have also surfaced: a resident's garden with room for a storage container, and an unused underground car park at a site earmarked for future development, plus an interested charity-run industrial unit just across the border in Haringey.

The search for a larger, dedicated hub site is separately underway and separately stalled. No suitable council-owned site has been identified yet, and several candidate sites fail on a basic constraint: no room for an articulated lorry to access or turn without blocking the surrounding road. A council-run community hall was raised too, but comes with its own access complications and sits with a separate team. Officers are keeping a shared log and reaching out across council departments, without a firm result so far. A separate, still-open question: whether collective buying needs its own legal entity, or can run through an existing organisation's structure and cash flow.

THE STATE OF PLAY, IN SHORT

Vision	A collective food co-op, backed by shared storage and buying power
Lead	Not yet confirmed — the agreed first move doesn't wait for one
Agreed first move	Phone round of every community food org, to establish real buying power
Coordinating bodies	The Hackney Food Network (grassroots) and the relaunching Hackney Food Partnership (food-system policy)
Small-scale option	Grocer warehouse in Stamford Hill, up to ~9 pallets indicated
Other sites in the mix	A garden storage container, an unused car park, a Haringey industrial unit
Large-site search	Ongoing, no council-owned site identified yet
Binding constraint	Vehicle access — most candidate sites can't take an articulated lorry
Next fixed point	The group's next monthly session, provisionally 12 October

What every other hub already found

None of Hackney's open questions are new to this group. Here's what the rest of the working group already learned that speaks directly to where Hackney needs more coordination.

HACKNEY'S QUESTION: NO CLEAR LEAD

Camden + Islington's hub runs on one accountable operator, not a committee

The Regis Road hub works because a single commercial wholesaler operates it day to day, co-located with the redistribution partner, while the boroughs provide investment rather than run it themselves — a maximum of £400,000 over two years, on the expectation the hub becomes financially independent after that, for around 15 tonnes of food a week (roughly £1.5m/year in value) reaching an estimated 50 organisations with substantial new volume. The group's own "Learning from outside the room" findings go further: hub failure risk sits in operator skillset, not good intentions — a past programme incubating regional hubs found many well-intentioned suppliers simply lacked the commercial background to run one as a business.

The lesson to carry over: Hackney's structuring session should treat "who operates this" as the first decision, not a detail to settle later — and the answer doesn't have to be a new organisation built from scratch.

[SEE THE FULL FINDING ↗](#)

HACKNEY'S QUESTION: NO DEDICATED SITE YET

Tower Hamlets has run for years on a meanwhile site, not a permanent one

Tower Hamlets' hub still doesn't have chilled or frozen capacity — that remains its binding constraint — but it has operated for years on a meanwhile site with a long rent-free term, while longer-term tenure is explored in parallel. Camden + Islington's own hub is a three-year meanwhile site too.

The lesson to carry over: a permanent, purpose-built site isn't the precondition for starting. Hackney's small-scale grocer-warehouse option can begin now, in parallel with the longer site search, not instead of it.

[SEE THE HUB ANATOMY ↗](#)

HACKNEY'S QUESTION: SURPLUS, BUYING, OR BOTH?

A hub doesn't have to choose one market over the other

The group's outside-learning session raised an open design question directly relevant here: a hub built with the right governance could serve both nutrient-dense organic supply and surplus redistribution from the same infrastructure, rather than treating them as separate systems. Newham's hub already shows one version of "more than one job" — it doubles as a public-health distribution point, though the social value that creates is genuinely hard to price for funders.

The lesson to carry over: design the Stamford Hill pilot to be able to hold both a collective-buying model and a surplus-redistribution role, even if it starts doing only one — retrofitting that later is harder than building it in from day one.

[SEE THE FULL FINDING ➤](#)

HACKNEY'S QUESTION: WHO PAYS FOR WHAT?

Space economics need to be stated plainly, early

At the Camden food hub, the commercial partner pays real (if discounted) rent while the redistribution partner pays nothing for space — not preferential treatment, just a landlord charging different tenants differently. Camden + Islington also show that a co-located commercial wholesaler can absorb much of a hub's running cost, rather than the council carrying all of it.

The lesson to carry over: get clear, early, on what the Stamford Hill grocer is actually being asked to give free versus what he needs paying for — labour and delivery support especially — rather than letting the arrangement default into an assumption either side later resents.

[SEE THE FULL FINDING ➤](#)

HACKNEY'S QUESTION: WILL INSTITUTIONS ACTUALLY TAKE THE FOOD?

Newham's own attempt to push surplus into school catering ran into fixed menus

Newham tried routing surplus food into its school catering system and the chefs simply couldn't use it — menus are set in advance, and there was no built-in flexibility to adapt on short notice. The food was good; the format wasn't ready for it. It's a live warning for any procurement-side ambition, not just Hackney's: institutional catering has to be designed for flexibility from the outset, not asked to absorb it after the fact.

The lesson to carry over: if Hackney's collective-buying work ever reaches school or public-sector catering, build menu flexibility into the agreement itself — don't assume goodwill will bridge a fixed-menu system.

— CONCRETE, NOT ANOTHER OPEN CONVERSATION

What's next for Hackney

Updated after the group's structuring session. The point of writing them down here is so the next session starts from this list, not from zero.

HACKNEY

Council officers, community groups, the local working group

-
- | | | |
|----|---|------|
| 01 | Held the structuring session and agreed a first move everyone can act on now, rather than waiting for a lead to be confirmed. | DONE |
|----|---|------|
-
- | | | |
|----|--|-----------------------|
| 02 | Call round every Hackney community food organisation directly to find out real monthly food spend — replacing the earlier written survey, which got almost no responses — to establish the group's actual collective buying power. | AGREED — STARTING NOW |
|----|--|-----------------------|
-
- | | | |
|----|--|------|
| 03 | Follow up directly with the Stamford Hill grocer to confirm usable space (now indicated at up to around nine pallets), cost, and what practical sorting/delivery support the pilot needs from the group. | OPEN |
|----|--|------|
-
- | | | |
|----|--|------|
| 04 | Identify which specific Hackney community organisations want to take part in a small-scale collective-buying trial first, rather than designing for all of them at once. | OPEN |
|----|--|------|
-
- | | | |
|----|---|-----------|
| 05 | Resolve whether collective buying needs its own legal entity, or can run through an existing organisation's structure and cash flow — raised directly as an open risk question, not yet answered. | TO DECIDE |
|----|---|-----------|
-
- | | | |
|----|---|-------------|
| 06 | Consolidate the borough's informal site-search log into one shared document — now covering the grocer's warehouse, a resident's garden storage option, an unused underground car park, and a community hall — so council teams stop independently approaching the same landlords. | IN PROGRESS |
|----|---|-------------|
-

- | | | |
|-------|---|---------------|
| 07 | Decide on an anchor-tenant model for the pilot site — an established local cooperative as the organisational face others can plug into, rather than a leaderless collective. | TO DECIDE |
| <hr/> | | |
| 08 | Connect the food-hub work explicitly into the borough's economic development strategy conversation already under way, to test funding and meanwhile-space routes. | FOLLOW-UP DUE |
| <hr/> | | |
| 09 | Follow up the Haringey lead directly — an interested charity-run industrial unit just across the border, on top of the Stamford Hill site's existing cross-borough relationships. | OPEN |

THE WORKING GROUP

Dark Matter Labs, Felix Project, the wider network

- | | | |
|-------|--|----------|
| 10 | Identify Hackney's own equivalents of Camden's three lead roles — a senior sponsor, a health & wellbeing lead, and a food lead — so Dark Matter Labs can map them alongside the same roles in other London boroughs. | OPEN |
| <hr/> | | |
| 11 | Plan a Sustain-style experiential workshop for Hackney's senior leaders and councillors, mirroring the format already run in Camden, to build political backing for the work. | PLANNED |
| <hr/> | | |
| 12 | Bring a written case study of how a comparable food collective was built from scratch elsewhere in the UK, as a working template rather than a blank page. | INCOMING |
| <hr/> | | |
| 13 | Fold Hackney's specifics back into the Hub Documentation library and the main working group page, so the next borough starting this inherits it too. | ONGOING |

The point of this list: Hackney doesn't need a new theory of how this should work — Lambeth, Newham, Tower Hamlets and Camden + Islington have already tested most of the open questions. What's missing is a named lead — and the group has now agreed a first, small, concrete step that doesn't wait for one. Items 02–03 are that step.

A working note for the newest borough joining the London Hubs & Markets Working Group, part of Dark Matter Labs' Food as Infrastructure portfolio.

Where Hackney is now

What the group already found

What's next

Wider portfolio

Hubs & Markets Working Group ↗

Food as Infrastructure ↗

Six Pathways to a Civic Food System ↗

Source: a Hackney food hub working session, September 2026, cross-referenced against the London Hubs & Markets Working Group's existing findings. Names of individuals are omitted by default; organisations already named elsewhere on this site (Felix Project, Dark Matter Labs, Sustain) are named here too.

Parts of this page were drafted with AI assistance (Claude). Licensed CC BY-SA 4.0 — see the [homepage](#) for full credit and lineage.